Preprint; forthcoming in *The Artificial Intelligence Revolution* (Eds Rangeley, Fairfax), Springer Nature

Updated 2 April 2026 (incorporating corrections)

The Most Dangerous Fiction: The Rhetoric and Reality of the AI Race

Seán S. ÓhÉigeartaigh
Centre for the Future of Intelligence
University of Cambridge

Abstract:

Are the US and China locked in a race to artificial general intelligence (AGI) and global strategic dominance? Through analysis of policy documents, public statements, and industry developments from 2017-2025, this chapter traces the emergence of the 'AI race' narrative. It distinguishes between general AI competition and the more consequential claim that China is racing toward AGI—a threshold that proponents argue could enable permanent strategic advantage. It critically evaluates the evidence for Chinese pursuit of AGI, finding limited support for claims of a concentrated state-led effort. The analysis reveals how the 'AI race' narrative has been used in the US to justify accelerated AI development and reduced regulatory oversight, despite rhetoric from Chinese officials calling for cooperation and safety to be prioritized. The chapter argues that the narrative functions as a potentially self-fulfilling prophecy that could accelerate dangerous race dynamic while undermining prospects for international cooperation on AI safety. It concludes with recommendations for reframing competitive dynamics, identifying opportunities for cooperation on shared safety challenges, and maintaining communication mechanisms to prevent miscalculation as AI capabilities advance.

Table of Contents

Introduction **1**
PART 1: LARGE LANGUAGE MODELS AND EMERGENCE OF THE AI RACE **3**
PART 2: AGI AND THE RACE FOR DECISIVE STRATEGIC ADVANTAGE **7**
PART 3: EXAMINING THE EVIDENCE: IS CHINA REALLY RACING TO AGI? **12**
PART 4: IMPLICATIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS **15**

Introduction

In 2018, Stephen Cave and I published *An AI Race for Strategic Advantage: Rhetoric and Risks* (Cave & ÓhÉigeartaigh, 2018). The paper documented the early emergence of a particular type of competitive framing around artificial intelligence (AI): as a race that could and must be won for geopolitical advantage. We highlighted the risk that the rhetoric alone could act as a self-fulfilling prophecy, helping to spark a race where it did not meaningfully

exist beforehand; and that should such a race develop, it could undermine essential governance and lead to corner-cutting on safety. We called for a reframing of AI development for shared global benefit, and with emphasis on global cooperation around safety-critical challenges.

Seven years on, as we feared, this narrative has become dominant in Western AI media and policy discourse. It is used to frame at one level the competition between leading companies to be the first to achieve artificial general intelligence, and at a level above, the technological competition between the US and China, where the leading companies are based. Moreover, the narrative informs and is informed by practical developments: the shape of the underlying technology and its rate of progress; competition over resources such as computing hardware, energy, expertise and insights; and policies being enacted by leading nations.

Despite this I argue that the narrative of a US-China AI race for global dominance began as, and in significant regards remains to date, a fiction. A race needs at least two competitors trying to win. However the race narrative in its stronger forms is nearly exclusively promoted in the West, and does not reflect the framing of AI competition and AI development in China in important respects. In the West the race narrative is increasingly used to justify progress at all costs, including justifying policies that benefit AI companies' interests over those of other parts of society.

Even in the West there remain important ambiguities around this AI race, and what different stakeholders have in mind when they invoke the notion. To the extent that there is a race ongoing, there is also an important 'race within a race' which deserves special attention: a race to AGI and decisive strategic advantage. In most contexts, commentators use the term 'AI race' to refer to a broad phenomenon: the competition to be in a leading position in AI development and deployment. Its characteristics are no different than any other technology race: it is good to be 'winning', but there is no permanent 'victory' and a competitor may catch up at any point. However, there is a separate notion within AI that once a certain threshold is passed in AI capability, AI systems may be able to contribute to accelerating AI research and development itself, maintaining or even extending a permanent advantage for the leading actor: decisive strategic advantage. This latter concept features prominently in analyses of trajectories towards artificial general intelligence (AGI) and has been alluded to or cited explicitly by the CEOs of several of the leading companies. It is a very different type of race, and has very different implications.

In this chapter I will trace the emergence of the broader AI race narrative, and how it evolved with the scaling paradigm underpinning today's frontier AI systems. I will then explore how this narrative has been used to justify reduced regulatory oversight and how it has dovetailed with rhetoric around a military AI arms race. It is increasingly claimed that the USA is, or will soon be, in a race with China to achieve AGI and decisive strategic advantage, with existential consequences for the future of the USA should it lose. I will analyse this particular sub-narrative, and the evidence that China is an active competitor in this perceived race. I will offer recommendations for navigating an international landscape increasingly shaped by these narratives, and for achieving the necessary points of cooperation needed to safeguard all nations in the face of a technology that may prove unlike any that has come before.

PART 1: LARGE LANGUAGE MODELS AND EMERGENCE OF THE AI RACE

Discourse around AI leadership [1] as a geopolitical priority became particularly prominent from 2017 onwards. Statements by technology leaders like Elon Musk, who tweeted "competition for AI superiority at national level [is the] most likely cause of WW3" (Musk. 2017) and political leaders like Vladimir Putin, who stated that "whoever becomes the leader in this sphere will become the ruler of the world' (Gigova, 2017), were breathlessly reported across Western media. The China State Council's 2017 "Next Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" was widely reported in Western media as pursuing global dominance in AI (Shead 2017, Demchak 2019). While the Plan did state that "AI has become a new focus of international competition", subtleties lost in translation may have resulted in references to becoming 'a primary innovation centre' in the Chinese plan becoming seen as an ambition to achieve dominance (ÓhÉigeartaigh et al., 2020).

Even more striking was the use of a statement made by President Xi Jinping in a Politburo session in 2018, that China must "*ensure that our country marches in the front ranks where it comes to theoretical research in this important area of AI, and occupies the high ground in critical and AI core technologies"* (Creemers and Kania, 2018). The sentence was echoed in policy reports and speeches in the US to support claims that AI featured heavily in China's plan to change the status quo if its geopolitical competition with the USA (Levine & Hwang 2025); and to support the assertion that China is in a military AI arms race with the US. The US Secretary of Defence quoted it in a speech calling for the private sector to overcome their unease about working with the US military, and requesting increased funding from Congress (Esper, 2019). However, Jinping's original speech, titled "Advancing the Healthy Development of Our Nation's New Generation of Artificial Intelligence" is an exhaustively detailed call for AI to be developed and used to benefit and modernise Chinese industries, its economy, and the livelihoods of its people, in the middle of which the above sentence is buried. No mention of military, defence or geopolitical aims or applications are made, beyond the anodyne call for China to be a leader in this new technology.

Perhaps more notable was a 2018 address by President Xi to that year's Fourth Industrial Revolution-themed BRICS Summit, where he highlighted breakthroughs in technologies such as AI, and emphasised how rounds of disruptive technology evolution had profoundly reshaped the course of human history (Xi, 2018). Chinese scholars subsequently analysed these remarks in the context of global order transitions (Ding, 2024), with one prominent scholar arguing that the Fourth Industrial Revolution would be a contest between the US and China, in which he claimed China could at least keep pace with, and might even beat, the USA (Jin, 2019).

Prominent commentators such as Kai-Fu Lee warned of top Silicon Valley AI scientists relocating to China to join Chinese AI companies (Lee, 2018). Analyses released in 2019 noted the relative proportions of technical papers and patents being produced in AI in China relative to the US, warning that China could soon overtake the US (O'Meara, 2019). The US National Security Commission on Artificial Intelligence (NSCAI)'s 2021 Report stated *"The race to research, develop and deploy AI and associated technologies is intensifying the*

[1] This section relates to AI as a broader field; while documents by AGI-focused companies are referred to, specific discussion of the emerging competitive focus on AGI will be covered in Part 2.

technology competition that underpins a wider strategic competition." Its Chairs' note warned: "*China's plans, resources, and progress should concern all Americans*." (Schmidt & Work, 2021)

From 2020 the resource inputs required to develop leading AI systems began to increase massively as the large language model (LLM) paradigm began to yield significant results. The promise of this approach hit public consciousness with the release of OpenAI's ChatGPT in November 2022. These models were notable for the ability of a single model to achieve breakthrough performances across tasks ranging from essay-writing to code generation to mathematics questions: general-purpose AI.

The resource-intensive nature of this approach has played an important role in shaping the geopolitical discussions around AI. Each successive generation of frontier-pushing model has required a multiple of the amount of compute and data to train compared to previous generations (Sevilla & Roldan, 2024; Villalabos et al., 2024). Recent estimates put the cost of training models at hundreds of millions of dollars, reaching over a billion dollars by 2027 (Cottier, 2024). Much of this pays for high-end graphical processing unit (GPU) chips, which have become a hard fought-over commodity. Other essential ingredients are data, energy, water (mostly for datacentre cooling) and human talent.

As this resource-heavy paradigm has taken shape, it has shaped the policies leading nations have adopted to gain or maintain their lead. For example, policymakers have become increasingly concerned about access to essential resources such as high-end chips, and aware of the globe-spanning supply chains that produce them. This is most clearly exemplified by the US semiconductor export controls, focused on limiting China's access to advanced semiconductors, chip-making equipment, and relevant expertise from US citizens, with a particular focus on chips that could be used for AI and supercomputing (U.S. Department of Commerce, 2022). These were initially announced in October 2022, with several further updates to expand their scope. China has responded by restricting export of rare earth minerals used in semiconductor manufacture to the US (Brasher, 2024).

LLMs developed by US companies have dominated the frontier of AI to date. Chinese companies have developed notable LLMs, such as Baidu's ERNIE series and Alibaba's Tongyi Qianwen. However, these have typically been regarded as a year or more behind the frontier set by the performance of leading LLMs (Mozur et al., 2024) although some benchmark performances suggest the gap may be tightening (Maslej et al., 2025). Export controls are likely to have played a significant role in maintaining the gap: in summer 2024 DeepSeek's CEO stated that the biggest bottleneck his company faced was access to the chips they needed (Schneider et al., 2024). Despite this, DeepSeek itself has made notable strides, releasing models that demonstrated performance equivalent to models released within the previous year by frontier-leading companies such as OpenAI, but estimated to have required a fraction of the computing resources to train (Liu et al, 2024; Joshi, 2025; Amodei, 2025). Despite continual model and hardware efficiency gains (Pilz et al., 2025a), demand for chips is expected to continue to increase, as larger models continue to be trained, and as more computing resources are used for the operation of trained models (Pilz et al., 2025b; Kumar & Manning, 2025).

An AI race to the bottom

In our 2018 paper Stephen Cave and I warned that an AI race rhetoric would be used as justification for corner-cutting on safety and regulation (Cave & ÓhÉigeartaigh, 2018). This fear appears to have been borne out, as AI has become ever more embedded within the narrative of rivalry between the US hegemon and its closest global competitor. Former Google CEO Eric Schmidt, an influential voice in US policy and security, has made this argument several times, for example in 2021:*"Why don't we wait until something bad happens and then we can figure out how to regulate it... Trust me, China is not busy stopping things because of regulation."* (Tech Transparency Project, 2024)

From 2020 onwards, funding for US foreign policy think tanks from a number of leading Big Tech companies increased significantly; according to the Financial Times these think tanks have promoted the argument that stricter regulations would threaten US competitiveness with a rising China (Stacey & Gilbert, 2022). OpenAI has used the threat from China not only to minimise regulation on themselves, but to bypass protections for other industries. In its 2025 evidence submission to the White House's Request for Information for its AI Action Plan, OpenAI argued for an approach which emphasises *"voluntary partnership between the federal government and the private sector, and neutralizes potential PRC benefit from American AI companies having to comply with overly burdensome state laws."* (Lehane, 2025)
OpenAI further argued for access to copyright-protected material: *"If the PRC's developers have unfettered access to data and American companies are left without fair use access, the race for AI is effectively over. America loses, as does the success of democratic AI."*

Prominent venture capitalist Marc Andreessen, an adviser to the Trump administration, has argued against policy interventions motivated by AI safety concerns, and has asserted "*The single greatest risk of AI is that China wins global AI dominance and we – the United States and the West – do not"*. (Andreessen, 2024)

Trump Administration AI Czar David Sacks justified the rescinding of the Biden AI Executive Order by claiming
"DeepSeek R1 shows that the AI race will be very competitive and that President Trump was right to rescind the Biden EO, which hamstrung American AI companies without asking whether China would do the same. (Obviously not.)" (Sacks, 2025)

It is far from clear whether this particular claim reflects reality. Since 2023 China has been developing quite heavy-handed AI regulation particularly in generative AI (Sheehan, 2023, Toner et al. 2023), that some analysts suggest would slow down their technology companies more than Western counterparts (Tobin, 2023; Abiri & Huang, 2023). For example, full public release of various LLMs have been delayed pending regulatory approvals (Su et al., 2023), with Baidu's Ernie Bot seeing a 6 month delay (South China Morning Post, 2023). The Decision of the Chinese Communist Party's Third Plenum stated a further commitment to "*institute oversight systems to ensure the safety of artificial intelligence*" (The State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2024). The frontier AI-relevant stipulations of the Biden Executive Order included safety testing, security measures, infrastructure requirements and reporting requirements, but these were primarily limited to the very largest, most advanced AI models (Executive Office of the President, 2023; Mayer Brown, 2024).

Achieving dominance has taken centre stage even for the most safety-conscious US companies. Anthropic's 2025 submission to the US Request for Information, calling for rapid scale-up of procurement of AI across government, heavy investment in AI-supporting energy

infrastructure, and security-bolstering measures, concluded with a call to the Administration to *"enable American dominance in AI by unlocking the benefits of this technology and ensuring that America remains dominant over China and our other adversaries.*" (Anthropic, 2025a). In March 2025 commentator Ezra Klein reflected that it seemed potentially 'historically dangerous' that *"A.I. has reached maturation at the exact moment that the U.S. and China are in this Thucydides' trap-style race for superpower dominance."* (Klein. 2025).

This framing of US-China technological competition as a high-stakes race follows what international relations scholars call 'securitization' (Buzan et al., 1998), where an issue is transformed from a normal political topic into an existential security threat that justifies extraordinary measures. By framing AI as a winner-takes-all technology, proponents create a powerful imperative for action while limiting critical examination of the overall premise.

The military dimension

The sub-narrative of a military AI arms race between the US and China has featured with growing intensity in US tech and policy rhetoric. According to Semafor former US Secretary of Defence Mark Esper has claimed the US is in an existential struggle with China in "an ongoing race for dominance" in AI (Solomon. 2023).

Alex Karp, CEO of Palantir which provides AI tools including LLMs to governments for intelligence and military purposes, has stated *"It's either: we own AI or our adversaries China and Russia own AI… We have to dominate, and then set a rule of law"*. (Griffin 2024) Palantir has multiple links to the present US administration, including through AI Czar David Sacks who was an early investor. In January 2025, Anduril announced plans to build a major factory in Ohio, home state of early Anduril investor JD Vance, to produce tens of thousands of autonomous systems and weapons annually. Its CEO stated:*"We don't have time for business as usual. We're predicted to run out of munitions within the first eight days of a potential conflict with China"*. (Chapman & Ludlow. 2025)

In 2024, OpenAI deleted language in its usage policy prohibiting use of its technology for military purposes (Biddle, 2024), and announced a partnership with Anduril to develop and deploy advanced AI for national security missions; Anduril's announcement referenced "the accelerating race between the United States and China" in AI (Anduril Industries, 2024). Meta revised its policy and announced it was making its Llama models available to US defence and national security agencies (Clegg, 2024). Anthropic partnered with Palantir and Amazon Web Services (AWS) to bring Claude models to US intelligence and defense agencies (Palantir Investor Relations, 2024), with Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei stating a "worry" that "*our adversaries – like China or Russia – may be better at deploying what they have to their own governments"* (Murgia, 2024). In 2025 Google dropped its commitment to rule out applications "likely to cause harm", arguing that companies and democratic governments should work together on AI that supports national security (Hooker & Vallance, 2025).

There is little Chinese public rhetoric explicitly discussing a US-China military arms race although there is evidence of significant investment in military integration of AI (Fedasiuk et al., 2021). The combination of China's substantial military buildup and modernization (Gadzala Tirziu, 2024), an explicit focus on military-AI integration (Stokes, 2024), and China's program of civil-military fusion facilitating the adoption of civilian innovations

(Shipley, 2024) provide a reasonable basis for Western concerns regarding China's military AI trajectory. A senior executive at a leading Chinese defense company is reported to have described AI as a "leapfrog technology", a technology allowing a lagging actor to skip ahead, and that "an ever-increasing military use of AI is inevitable" in a 2018 speech (Allen, 2023). Notably this talk was not made available online, suggesting that other talks and information relevant to China's ambitions for AI in military context may not be available in the public domain to the degree US equivalents are.

Balanced against this are official policy documents and public remarks raising concerns around unfettered application of AI in military domains. China's Position Paper on Regulating Military Applications of Artificial Intelligence (2021), submitted to the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), calls for *"dialogue, cooperation and an effective governance regime in order to prevent serious harms or even disasters caused by military applications of AI to mankind"*. It calls for regulation to *"safeguard global strategic stability, prevent arms race*" among other goals, and states
"While developing advanced weapon systems and enhancing their legitimate defense capabilities, countries need to bear in mind that military applications of AI shall never be used as a tool to start a war or pursue hegemony. We oppose moves to undermine the sovereignty and territorial security of other countries by using advantages in AI technology".
A 2024 analysis of Chinese-language journal articles by PLA members and other experts notes as a key finding
"Contrary to some US discussions of China's views on military AI, many of the Chinese experts whose arguments have been analysed in this report voice misgivings about using insufficiently trustworthy AI systems in military contexts. They also express concerns about the risks of outbreaks or escalations of wars" (Bresnick, 2024)
In 2024 scientists from the West and China, including notable thinkers influential in policy such as Andrew Yao and Xue Lan, signed a statement on 'red lines' that AI systems should not cross. This included the use of AI to facilitate design of weapons of mass destruction or autonomous cyberattacks (IDAIS-Beijing, 2024).

In this domain, however, the connection between public rhetoric and actual action is more tenuous, as on both the US and Chinese side much of the relevant discussion and planning will be classified.

PART 2: AGI AND THE RACE FOR DECISIVE STRATEGIC ADVANTAGE

The emergence of the race to AGI

The progress in general-purpose AI systems such as LLMs have seen a rehabilitation of a long-held goal in AI: artificial general intelligence, or AGI. AGI describes an as-yet hypothetical AI system that can perform all or nearly all tasks typically requiring the intelligence of humans, to a standard equivalent or better than that achieved by most humans (Shanahan, 2015). In principle AGI could automate most or all of the intellectual work of science and engineering. This includes areas where human expertise is in limited supply and where training human experts requires years; thousands of AGI systems could be spun up to work in parallel, and at machine speeds rather than limited by human work speed.

In academic discussion the concept of AGI is usually closely linked to that of superintelligence (Bostrom, 2014). AGI systems would be expected to automate the process of AGI development itself, meaning that progress in AI itself would no longer run at human speeds. If achieved, this might rapidly result in broadly superintelligent systems massively more capable than the best human teams, which could then rapidly accelerate progress in all other major scientific and industrial endeavours.

Many scholars and technologists believe the development of AGI and superintelligence carry risks of catastrophic consequences, up to and including the full extinction of humanity. These outcomes might arise through misuse of the advanced capabilities of superintelligence by humans, or through loss of control of systems that would by definition be faster and more capable than humans in most cognitive domains (Hendrycks et al., 2023). Of particular concern on the path to AGI and superintelligence is the potential emergence of recursive self-improvement: the ability for AI systems to automate their own improvement. Anthropic and OpenAI, and Google DeepMind all note recursive self-improvement as a key concern in their safety frameworks (Anthropic, 2025b; OpenAI, 2025a) or safety approach paper (Shah et al., 2025). OpenAI notes that recursive self-improvement could increase capabilities and risks sufficiently rapidly to make their current oversight practices "*insufficient to identify and mitigate new risks, including risks to maintaining human control of the AI system itself*." While the prospect of AGI and superintelligence being achieved in coming years remains a subject of significant expert disagreement, a high proportion of those who take the prospect seriously consider them to plausibly present an existential risk to humanity (Centre for AI Safety, 2023). Based on past statements this includes frontier CEOs Dario Amodei, who 'guesses' a 10-25% risk of extinction from AI (Roose, 2023), Sam Altman (Altman, 2015), Elon Musk (Pillay, 2025) and Demis Hassabis (Milmo, 2024).

The release of GPT-4 in 2023 demonstrated that a single model could achieve breakthrough performances across tasks as varied as essay-writing, conversation, coding, and sitting legal examinations (Achiam et al., 2023). AGI began being discussed as a goal by companies, and a possibility that might need more imminent preparation by policymakers. Elon Musk launched xAI in March 2023 to produce "a competitive alternative" to leading AI companies and with the explicit aim of building AGI, predicting that AGI would be viable by 2029 (Kerner, 2023). In April 2023 Google announced the merger of their AI research divisions Brain and DeepMind (Pichai, 2023) in order to better compete in developing increasingly general AI systems. Google cofounder Sergei Brin would later state "*We fully intend that Gemini [Google DeepMind's leading frontier AI system] will be the very first AGI*" (Hart, 2025). DeepSeek launched in July 2023, with "*unraveling the mystery of AGI with curiosity"* in its mission statement (Schneider et al., 2024). Former OpenAI cofounder Ilya Sutskever launched Safe Superintelligence in 2024. Going even further in ambition, the company is described as having "one goal and one product: a safe superintelligence." (Sutskever et al., 2024)

By 2025, AGI has entered regular public discourse. Google Deepmind's Hassabis has predicted AI capable of achieving Einstein-level scientific breakthroughs as being 50/50 likely by 2030, a feat that would assume AGI (The Economist, 2025). In January 2025 OpenAI's Sam Altman stated he thought it likely that AGI will be developed within the 2025-29 US presidential term (Tyrangiel, 2025), and wrote *"We are now confident we know how to build AGI as we traditionally understood it… We are beginning to turn our aim beyond that, to superintelligence in the true sense of the word"* (Altman. 2025)

While not using the term AGI, Anthropic's Dario Amodei described the prospect of 'a country of geniuses in a datacentre', and predicted this could be achieved "*possibly by 2026 or 2027*" (Amodei, 2025a). In this context, hundreds of billions of dollars combined are being invested in companies aiming to achieve AGI, and in supporting infrastructure.

Despite the momentous implications of these pronouncements, both public and policy discourse around the prospects of AGI remain muted, on the whole. Many policymakers regard AGI as industry hype, or as a metaphorical concept not to be taken literally (Colson, 2024). A substantial portion of the academic community, including many senior experts advising decision-makers, do not consider current approaches as likely to lead to AGI (Jones, 2025). Discussion of AGI has also suffered from a confusion of concepts and definitions (Mitchell, 2024): weaker definitions have been put forward (Aguera y Arcas & Norvig. 2023), and the distinction between 'AGI' and 'general-purpose AI' may often be unclear.

The implications of AGI as envisaged by the AGI companies are sufficiently extreme that they are intuitively implausible; superintelligence even more so. Altman writes:
"*Superintelligent tools could massively accelerate scientific discovery and innovation well beyond what we are capable of doing on our own... This sounds like science fiction right now, and somewhat crazy to even talk about it.*" (Altman, 2025)
Thus the magnitude of the technological step change anticipated by technologists like Altman may not be clear to decision-makers; or may seem too fantastical to take seriously.

There is a clear difference in expectation between frontier CEOs and most political leaders regarding what will be possible within the next 5-10 years. The disconnect is obscured by the common use of terms such as AGI and the 'AI race', where these terms have vastly different meanings to different stakeholders. This has especially important implications for the strategic and geopolitical implications of an AI race.

A race that can be 'won': Decisive strategic advantage

A Google search of "AI race" returns pages of news stories framing nearly every major development in AI and associated infrastructure in terms of its impact on 'the AI race'. Sometimes the 'AI race' refers broadly to competitive progress in AI; often it specifically refers to US-China AI competition. Most of this coverage is not notably different in tone from how a wide range of other emerging technologies are discussed, although often AI's wide-ranging applications are noted. In a normal technology competition, it is good to lead, but the long-term future of geopolitics is unlikely to be decided by it.

For those targeting the development of AGI, a much more specific and consequential race is unfolding: a race for decisive strategic advantage (Bostrom, 2014). The strong version of this scenario has three underpinning assumptions:
(1) AI can itself be used to accelerate AI research
(2) The results of this accelerated AI progress can be translated into accelerated advances in scientific, economic, and military domains
(3) Beyond a certain point, the lead attained in these domains can be maintained indefinitely or even increased, meaning that the leader can thereafter maintain a 'durable advantage' over adversaries.

The dynamics of this scenario are fundamentally different from those of a 'normal' technology competition (Narayanan & Kapoor, 2025). In normal circumstances while a

company or nation may be leading at any given time on any of a range of measures – performance, cost, adoption – there is no clear end point. Moreover, a competitor can usually catch up or even overtake through learning from or reverse engineering the leaders' breakthroughs, investing more resources and expertise, or theft of intellectual property. Nearly all AI progress to date, I argue, is best thought of as 'normal' technology competition, in which a race cannot meaningfully be won.

However some technology developments represent a phase change. In warfare, the development of the first atomic bomb resulted in a fundamentally new capability that changed the nature of warfare and geopolitics forever thereafter. There was a perceived race to develop the atomic bomb first, and a perception that getting there first mattered (Belfield & Ruhl, 2022). It is plausible that at some point there is a phase change in the development of AI where the capabilities of AI make it possible to maintain and consolidate the advantage of the lead actor indefinitely, and to translate this into a lasting global advantage.

This notion – decisive strategic advantage – is by no means universally accepted even amongst researchers who take seriously the prospect of AGI; for example Brundage and Werner (2025) write: "*The idea of a unipolar artificial general intelligence (AGI) scenario — where a single actor or coalition has exclusive control over very advanced AI capabilities — is contrary to the nature of AI technology*."
Even if a unipolar AGI scenario were achieved, Ding & Dafoe (2023) critique the notion that advances in AI would rapidly translate into substantial military improvement, casting doubt on the idea that 'winning' the race to AGI would rapidly result in military dominance sufficiently quickly to ensure decisive strategic advantage.

Nonetheless versions of the race for decisive strategic advantage are increasingly accepted, and are sometimes used as justification for more extreme actions than would otherwise be countenanced. This leads to a dangerous situation: obfuscated by the rhetoric around development of all forms of AI as a race, and the broader geopolitical competition between the US and China, some technology leaders, governance thinkers and perhaps some political decision makers have a much more specific and consequential US – China contest in mind.

In "The AI War and How to Win It: The Battle for the Future of the World", CEO of Scale AI Alexandr Wang stated [2] that *"The AI winner of this decade will be economically and militarily dominant for the next 50 years."* and that "*China is currently outpacing the United States*". (Wang, 2022)

In "On DeepSeek and Export Controls" Amodei noted
"*there's at least the possibility that, because AI systems can eventually help make even smarter AI systems, a temporary lead could be parlayed into a durable advantage. Thus, in this world, the US and its allies might take a commanding and long-lasting lead on the global stage."* (Amodei, 2025)

In "Machines of Loving Grace" Amodei emphasised the importance of liberal democracies having the upper hand globally at the point at which 'powerful AI' is introduced (Amodei, 2024). He further describes a 'carrot and stick' strategy for shaping the world, in which the

[2] As the term 'AGI' is often not used specifically, I have included quotes where context and scale of impact indicates authors have AGI-level AI capabilities in mind.

‘carrot’ of access to the huge scientific and economic advantages of powerful AI are offered to adversary nations in exchange for their adoption of liberal democracy. The ‘stick’ is the prospect of facing AI-powered militaries against which they would be hopelessly undermatched.

In ‘Situational Awareness’, published shortly after his departure from OpenAI, Leopold Aschenbrenner stated:
“Superintelligence will give a decisive economic and military advantage. China isn’t at all out of the game yet. In the race to AGI, the free world’s very survival will be at stake.” (Aschenbrenner, 2024)

Palantir’s Alex Karp has described the creation of AI weapons as “our Oppenheimer moment”, drawing direct comparison to calls from physicists to the US president to develop the nuclear bomb in 1939. In a 2023 essay, he described concerns around development of too-powerful AI resulting in human extinction as “not unjustified” but that the suggestion to halt development is “misguided”, arguing *“our adversaries will not pause to indulge in theatrical debates… They will proceed. This is an arms race of a different kind, and it has begun”.* (Karp, 2023)

In January 2025 Axios reported on a phonecall with outgoing National Security Adviser Jake Sullivan in which he warned that “*the next few years will determine whether artificial intelligence leads to catastrophe – and whether China or America prevails in the AI arms race*”.
The journalists stated “*Regardless of what was said in public, every background conversation we had with President Biden's high command came back to China… Every move, every risk was calculated to keep China from beating us to the AI punch. Nothing else matters, they basically said.”*
Sullivan, however, noted the importance of cooperation: *“Sullivan said Trump, like Biden, should try to work with Chinese leader Xi Jinping on a global AI framework, much like the world did with nuclear weapons.”* (VandeHei & Allen, 2025)

The stakes perceived by these technology leaders and a growing number of policy analysts justify actions that might be considered unthinkable in other circumstances. In “The Battle for Brilliant Minds: From the Nuclear Age to AI”, RAND senior political scientist Iskander Rehman detailed the 1944 US plan to assassinate Werner Heisenberg at an academic lecture, should it become clear that Germany was on track to develop the atomic bomb. After discussing the US-China AI race and the prospect of AGI, Rehman argued
“*if it appears that a foreign adversarial power is clearly taking the lead in developing a technology as hugely consequential as artificial general intelligence, U.S. security managers may need to reluctantly reacquaint themselves with some of the more shadowy and morally fraught chapters of their nation’s past — from the plot against Heisenberg to Operation Paperclip. Indeed, the stakes of the competition may demand no less.*” (Rehman, 2025)

Some commentators argue that any state pursuing superintelligence and decisive strategic advantage presents a direct threat to the survival of its peers. Hendrycks, Schmidt & Wang (2025) proposed a ‘Mutually Assured AI Malfunction’ (MAIM) deterrence regime modelled after Mutually Assured Destruction, in which it would be understood by leading states that their rival would be prepared to sabotage their AI capability should it become clear the state was making a “*grab for strategic monopoly*” through pursuing superintelligence. Sabotage interventions range from covert cyberattacks to kinetic strikes on datacentres, although the

paper acknowledged the option of broader hostilities through further escalations or threats to non-AI assets.

PART 3: EXAMINING THE EVIDENCE: IS CHINA REALLY RACING TO AGI?

But is China, or any nation other than the US, currently competing meaningfully in the race to AGI? In November 2024, the US-China Economic and Security Review Commission (USCC) released its annual report to Congress, with the following as its first recommendation:
"Congress establish and fund a Manhattan Project-like program dedicated to racing to and acquiring an Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) capability. AGI is generally defined as systems that are as good as or better than human capabilities across all cognitive domains and would surpass the sharpest human minds at every task." (US-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2024).

USCC commissioner Jacob Helberg, a senior adviser to the CEO of Palantir, told Reuters *"China is racing towards AGI ... It's critical that we take them extremely seriously"* (Tong & Martina, 2024).

However the 793 page report discussed AGI only in the sections recommending the US Manhattan Project-like program, and provided no evidence to support a claim that China is racing towards AGI; nor has Helberg provided evidence for this claim elsewhere. In discussing it, AI journalist Garrison Lovely argued that China hawks "are manufacturing an AI arms race" (Lovely, 2024).

In 2023 the Beijing Institute for General Artificial Intelligence (BIGAI)'s Director Zhu Songchun remarked on artificial general intelligence (AGI) as becoming "*a strategic high-ground in international technological competition over the next 10 to 20 years*" with an impact "*equivalent to the atomic bomb in the field of information technology*" (Zhao, 2023). However Zhu and BIGAI's focus on symbolic AI over large models and scaling have yet to demonstrate results comparable to that by leading large model companies in the US or China.

In 2023 following ChatGPT's release the Politburo emphasised development of '通用人工智能" (Xinhua News Agency, 2023), a term that could be translated as 'artificial general intelligence', but can also be translated to the more mundane 'general-purpose AI' used to denote systems such as ChatGPT. Subsequent state media strongly suggested general-purpose AI was intended (Chinatalk, 2025). Subsequent state media strongly suggested general-purpose AI was intended (ChinaTalk, 2025). General artificial intelligence was also included in a 2023 funding round from the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (MIIT), but with minimal funding and computational resources (General Office of the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology, 2023; ChinaTalk, 2025).

As noted by ChinaTalk (2025) the CEOs of several newer companies including Moonshot AI, Zhipu AI and Minimax AI have since voiced more unambiguous AGI ambitions, but the degree of investment they have is a fraction compared to AGI-focused companies in the West. A major AI funding scheme of 1 trillion RMB ($140 billion) was launched by the Bank

of China in January 2025, but intended to be spread across the entire AI research and application ecosystem, rather than AGI research (Bank of China, 2025).

The most compelling cases are Alibaba and Deepseek. In February 2025's Alibaba earnings call its CEO Eddie Wu described pursuit of AGI as its "primary objective" noting that AGI might "even replace 50% of global GDP" (PYMNTS, 2025). This was accompanied by the announcement of an investment of $53 billion over three years into AI infrastructure (Yahoo Finance, 2025). While the largest ever investment by Chinese private enterprise into AI, it pales in comparison to investments announced by US tech firms: Microsoft announced an $80 billion planned investment for 2025 alone. Forbes estimate Deepseek's valuation at $1-$10 billion (Tognini, 2025); for comparison OpenAI raised funding in March 2025 at a $300 billion valuation (OpenAI, 2025b). While Deepseek's success has resulted in meetings between its CEO with Premier Li Qiang and President Xi Jinping, this does not appear to have translated into a greater policy focus or state funding support for AGI (ChinaTalk, 2025).

DeepSeek state their goal to be AGI, but their rhetoric with regards to competition is more restrained than their Western competition. In a 2024 interview CEO Liang Wenfeng called for China to achieve leadership in AI, but the focus was on innovation over imitation: "*We often say that there is a gap of one or two years between Chinese AI and the United States, but the real gap is the difference between originality and imitation. If this doesn't change, China will always be only a follower — so some exploration is inescapable."* (Schneider et al., 2024)

In public rhetoric Wen Gao, Director of Peng Cheng Laboratory wrote in *People's Daily* that *"the development of global artificial intelligence is in the transition stage from weak artificial intelligence to strong artificial intelligence"* and that *"artificial intelligence is a strategic commanding height for competition among major powers."*
However the essay went on to say *"International cooperation and competition in artificial intelligence coexist"* noting US and EU policy measures to enhance their competitiveness, before calling for strengthening of international cooperation and global governance (Gao, 2025). Gao is a coauthor of a previous paper discussing recursive self-improvement and the risks of AGI development, which emphasised strengthening international AGI cooperation as "necessary" (Liu et al., 2021).

This mirrors recent policy rhetoric: at Davos Vice Premier Ding Xuexiang noted that the primary purpose of China's AI development is to drive economic transformation, achieve Chinese-style modernisation, and improve the lives of its 1.4 billion citizens; and that China "*will not blindly follow trends or engage in unrestrained international competition*". His speech noted that "*if left to uncontrolled competition among nations, the "gray rhino" risks will become imminent."* (Geopolitechs, 2025)

At the 2025 Paris AI Summit, senior diplomat Fu Ying described China's position as follows: *"China maintains a relatively calm attitude toward China-U.S. cooperation and global governance, advocating to respect each other's core interests and major concerns on divergent issues, adhering to the principles of mutual respect, peaceful coexistence, and win-win cooperation."*
However, the US drive for dominance is a clear source of frustration:

"Past years have witnessed consistent US efforts to block China's technological progress, poisoning the atmosphere for cooperation"
Fu repeated a statement she'd previously made in 2019: *"as long as the U.S. and China can cooperate and work together with the rest of humanity, we'll find a way to keep AI under control. But if countries remain at odds and even use advanced AI systems against each other, the machines are more likely to gain the upper hand."* (Fu. 2025)

At the April 2025 Politburo study session on AI, President Xi called for "*mastering core technologies such as high-end microchips and foundational software*" (Centre for Security and Emerging Technology, 2025) which analyst Paul Triolo perceived as a response to the threat of US policies isolating China in AI development. However, analysts Helen Toner and Kristy Loke noted the apparent lack of special interest in AGI or superintelligence compared to Silicon Valley discourse. Scott Singer, Gabriel Wagner and Jason Zhou picked up on the strong emphasis on safety, with a full paragraph of the speech summary dedicated to addressing AI's "*unprecedented risks and challenges*", and a further paragraph calling for *"broad international cooperation"* and *"global governance frameworks"*. (Loke et al., 2025).

Public and policy rhetoric by influential figures emphasises that China wishes to be a world-leader in AI, but in an international landscape where competition is balanced with cooperation, especially on safety. The emphasis of reports, speeches and essays is typically on a wide range of industry and economic applications of AI, rather than pursuit of superintelligence or global dominance. Self-sufficiency is a common theme; the risk of reliance on US technology and supply chains is clearly keenly felt. There certainly is a broader aspiration that progress in emerging technologies would contribute to a reshaping of the global order (Ding, 2024), but even in more ambitious rhetoric commentators look to a future with China and the US as two superpowers instead of the US as world's sole superpower (e.g. Jin, 2019). China clearly recognises AI as a geopolitically important technology. There are areas in which China is pursuing greater global influence in which AI and digital technologies play an important role, such as in the expansion of China's Belt and Road Initiative, and in efforts such as the Global AI Governance Initiative (Cyberspace Administration of China, 2023). However there is little evidence at present that China perceives AI or AGI in terms of more overt geopolitical dominance; and much evidence that strengthening China's economy, and achieving global economic advantage along lines more consistent with 'normal' technology competition are greater areas of focus.

Nonetheless rhetoric is an imperfect indicator of intent, and Chinese policy rhetoric is often less overt than Western rhetoric. Critics may also point to other prominent instances in which alleged PRC-linked actions are perceived to have diverged from public statements. For example, the Chinese Government has repeatedly stated that it opposes cyber espionage and attacks (Yousif & Tidy, 2024; People's Republic of China 2021). However US cybersecurity firms have published detailed technical analyses of attack campaigns they attribute to Chinese state-sponsored groups (FireEye 2019; FireEye 2013), and the US Department of Justice has issued multiple indictments against Chinese personnel and hackers for economic and cyber-espionage (U.S. Department of Justice, 2025; 2014).

It remains the case that neither public rhetoric, nor publicly available evidence relating to investment or concentration of relevant resources, indicates a major state-supported push towards AGI, nor an ambition to pursue global dominance through AI or superintelligence. It is just about possible that an ambitious, well-resourced AGI effort exists and is a state priority, but that no public information about it exists. But there are reasons to think this

unlikely at this time. Such a project would require huge resources in terms of high-end chips and expertise as well as energy, and some indications of it would likely be picked up by open-source intelligence and the AI research community - researchers usually have an idea where their more talented colleagues and PhD students have gone to. Even if it did, China would still be at a disadvantage due to limited access to leading chips. Chinatalk (2025) concludes that "*there are no signs of any "whole nation" 举国 effort to centralize resources"* towards any concerted AGI push.

PART 4: IMPLICATIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

For any technology of such strategic significance as AI/AGI, and with such extensive military and intelligence applications, much relevant information is likely to be classified. However, from publicly available information it appears that the narrative of the US-China 'AI race' has been overblown. In particular, the more specific narrative that China is locked in a race with the US to reach artificial superintelligence, and translate this to lasting geopolitical dominance, is almost entirely constructed and promoted by US-associated actors. I argue that challenging it is essential. Moreover, it is fully possible to do so while recognising the benefit to the US of pursuing export controls and other measures to strengthen its security and competitiveness. These measures all make sense within a 'normal' technology competition, and do not require the prospect of Chinese global strategic dominance through AI to be justified.

Many of the prominent actors promoting this rhetoric stand to benefit from it directly in important ways – through investments, permissive regulatory changes, and other forms of influence – and some are actively pushing recommendations that benefit them directly using the threat of Chinese AI dominance.[3] I do not claim that they are insincere in promoting this narrative; only that this is the effect of the rhetoric. In practice the race to AGI that exists is between predominantly US-headquartered companies, and is being run against each other.

The impacts of this narrative are considerable. It is being used to justify a reduced focus on regulations that aim to ensure the safety of the technology and minimise negative impacts on other industries and society more broadly. It serves to concentrate power and resources around those actors pushing the narrative. It increases international mistrust and undermines prospects of international cooperation on AI at the point at which it is arguably most needed. I argue that it creates the most dangerous possible circumstances in which to develop AGI; a technology many leading experts, including the CEOs of the leading companies developing it, think has a sizeable chance of bringing about human extinction.

This extensive narrative, and the expectations and fears of the US technologists and thought leaders promoting it, is of course visible to their Chinese counterparts. While it does not appear the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) or Chinese tech industry has responded substantially at time of writing, how long can that last? One possibility is that they become convinced of the capabilities and strategic decisiveness of artificial superintelligence, and indeed do invest far more of China's vast resources into trying to achieve it.

[3] One notable counterexample is Anthropic's recommendation to strengthen security measures in AI companies, which would be expected to introduce significant cost and inconvenience into the AI development process. (Anthropic, 2025a)

A race to superintelligence may eventually be inevitable as scientific consensus grows about its possibility and implications. If this prominent narrative hastens this race emerging, this surely does not serve US interests given the present US advantage in AGI-focused efforts. Nor does it benefit the world, given that such a race in earnest would increase competitive pressures and immediately make it more difficult to give adequate care to safety and control. It is also possible that a geopolitical race to superintelligence is not inevitable: China may not begin to focus in strength on superintelligence until the lead held by US entities is insurmountable. It is even possible that as consensus on the implications and risks of superintelligence grows, it becomes preferable for leading nations to participate in a cooperative global effort to avoid the risks of unsafe development (Katze & Futerman, 2024); however this seems far less plausible against the backdrop of a 'race for dominance' narrative. In all these cases the narrative of the race for decisive strategic advantage hastens the emergence of, or brings into reality, the race it warns of.

Another prospect is that China perceives the race as unwinnable if they perceive artificial superintelligence as imminent, given the present disparity in investment, chip infrastructure, and expertise. In this instance we might ask how any nation would respond to stated intentions of durable global hegemony from an adversary, promoted by influential thinkers close to that adversary's administration. In such circumstances even the prospect of great power conflict might become distressingly plausible (Werner, 2024).

The situation is complicated further by the confused mishmash of beliefs and expectations driving policy on AI at present. In arguing that international cooperation to control ASI (artificial superintelligence) is preferable and strategically sound, Katze and Futerman (2024) state
"The argument for racing to develop ASI also requires the assumption that states are (to some extent) rational actors and are well-informed about ASI's strategic implication".
However, I believe it is more likely that a possible race to superintelligence would unfold in a less coherent way. As it is now, some stakeholders will push their nation to win the race to AGI, with the prospect of full superintelligence, a massively accelerated industry, and a durable advantage over all other nations as their goal. To other stakeholders, such prospects will continue sounding like fantasy until much later, but the importance of remaining ahead in a strategically important 'normal' technology in a tense geopolitical contest will appear to justify at least some of the same actions. Whether or not those who believe near-term superintelligence is plausible are correct, this lack of shared understanding of the stakes at play is likely to be destabilising, and is likely to undermine both coherent national strategies and stable international agreements or even deterrence strategies. Would Mutually Assured Destruction have worked as a doctrine if decision makers within countries had vastly different conceptions of the destructive capacity of nuclear weapons?

What can be done?

A first priority is to assess the evidence justifying this powerful policy narrative, which this paper aims to contribute to. Belfield and Ruhl (2022) described how incorrect perceptions about tight arms races brought forward the development of powerful destructive technologies such as the nuclear bomb and intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs), developments that were subsequently regretted by some of their advocates. I argue that this may now be happening in AI.

It may also be important to achieve clarity between stakeholders on their expectations regarding superintelligence and its implications, although this is less clear-cut. If adversaries converge on an expectation of near-term superintelligence leading to decisive strategic advantage, this may exacerbate race dynamics. However, a growing number of governance and deterrence proposals rest on the assumption that adversaries are rational actors with a shared understanding of the stakes at play. At present this is very much not the case - there are clearly diverging expectations between companies and governments, between different stakeholders within governments, and between governments. If this persists into the future, it would undermine such proposals and introduce dangerous geopolitical instability.

Signalling benign intent should be a priority. As long as the US fears domination by its adversary should China achieve AGI first, and as long as US technologists signal that the US would itself pursue global hegemony with the aid of AGI, achieving cooperation seems unlikely. When asked if in a scenario where AI was "getting out of control" the US government could enact a 'pause on AI development, US Vice President Vance answered: "*The honest answer to that is that I don't know, because part of this arms race component is if we take a pause, does the People's Republic of China not take a pause? And then we find ourselves all enslaved to P.R.C.-mediated A.I.?"* (Douthat, 2025)
Clear, credible commitments by nations pursuing AGI to respect the sovereignty, political systems and economic well-being of rivals will be needed for cooperation to be feasible, and for countries to feel able to 'slow down' if safety concerns warrant it. A meaningful commitment to a regime for equitably sharing the benefits of AI, including with adversaries, would also reduce incentives to race.

A further priority is finding where cooperation is possible and beneficial. Even between perceived adversaries, there are areas where cooperation is in the best interests of both, and where cooperation need not be in conflict with competitive or geopolitical rivalry. For example, it is in both the US and China's interests that powerful models developed in either state be robustly protected against co-option and misuse, for example by non-state actors (Ó hÉigeartaigh, 2025); sharing techniques and best practices in this domain will benefit both. Both these nations have far more physical and digital infrastructure to protect than any non-state actor, making this an asymmetric threat. Bucknall et al. (2025) lay out a broader set of technical safety topics on which rivals could cooperate.

Establishing cooperation around topics of immediate shared benefit will be a step towards making international agreements with deeper regulatory implications possible. In a competitive technology development scenario, regulation provides an essential 'floor' for society and for the companies being regulated. The CEOs of leading AGI companies have expressed concern about risk and have in the past called for regulation (Altman et al., 2023; Amodei, 2023; Milmo, 2023). But no matter how risk-concerned a company is, within a tight race it cannot afford to be the one company to take far more burdensome steps than other actors, due to the competitive disadvantage this would pose the company (Armstrong et al., 2016). Regulation addresses this by establishing a requirement of all companies. This principle applies both within a country and between countries. As models become more powerful, more onerous regulations will become necessary for safety; however fears of losing international competitive advantage may prevent these being implemented nationally, a concern already reflected in US policy rhetoric. Thus only through both national regulation and agreed international standards (Trager et al., 2023) between 'racing' nations can a race to the bottom be avoided.

Political will is needed to reach the stage where certain international agreements would be feasible; for example commitment not to progress beyond key capability thresholds unless safety can be guaranteed. Such agreements could be significantly strengthened through mechanisms for guaranteeing and verifying compliance by rivals and third parties – for example, allowing international identification of unauthorised training runs, or training runs that do not meet agreed safety stipulations. Governance frameworks and interventions have been proposed, including at the hardware level (Trager et al., 2023; O'Gara et al., 2025; Petrie et al., 2025), and ensuring this toolkit is developed ahead of when it is needed should be a priority. Without a powerful suite of monitoring and verification tools, there seems little prospect of escape from a race motivated by fear of what the other is doing.

Throughout, maintaining lines of communication will be paramount. The current 'AI race' narrative might be partly dispelled if US policymakers had more access to their Chinese counterparts. Should a geopolitical race to AGI begin in earnest, then each participant understanding which actions might be misunderstood by rivals, including especially those that might provoke strong or unexpected responses, will be essential (Shoker et al., 2023). In the Cold War, complementary roles were played by a variety of channels – official political (Miller, 2021), track II (Kraft, 2024), and clandestine (Scott, 2013) – to avert disaster. It may seem sensationalist to draw comparison between Cold War standoffs and global pursuit of AGI, but the risks inherent in pursuing AGI under intense geopolitical rivalry (Futerman & Katze, 2024) may mean the stakes are even higher. Of particular importance will be avoidance of a rival initiating a stage of recursive improvement that may not be controllable under the pressure of the race dynamic; lines of communication to enable de-escalation from this step will be essential. We can only hope the world does not come to such a brink.

Conclusion

If what the leading frontier AI companies believe with regards to imminent artificial superintelligence turns out to be unfounded, then eventually it will become clear that the international AI competition currently underway is a 'normal technology competition', and that the extreme outcomes motivating the AI race for decisive strategic advantage can be discounted. In that instance, we may hope that this narrative has not resulted in some of the more drastic geopolitical moves that have been suggested.

If superintelligence is a genuine prospect, however, then the effect of the US-China 'race for decisive strategic advantage' narrative may well be to hasten, or even bring about, a headlong rush towards plausibly the most dangerous development in human history. Moreover, the narrative's overtly adversarial framing may undermine any realistic prospects of global cooperation on safety. It is therefore essential that we examine the evidence for the 'race' as it has existed to date, and the evidence to justify the actions now being proposed.

I argue that the stronger narratives around a US-China AI race have been overstated, and that the specific narrative of a US-China AI race for decisive strategic advantage, as currently presented in Western media and policy discourse, is one of the most dangerous fictions ever created. Moreover it is a fiction with the clear potential to serve as a self-fulfilling prophecy, bringing into being a true race that would be even more dangerous. The world should not be lost on the basis of a fiction.

Acknowledgements:

The author would like to thank the following for valuable discussions and comments on an earlier draft: Coleman Snell, Emma Bates, Kerry McInerney, Eleanor Drage, Greg Merckelbach, Rose Hadshar, Ariel Gil, Jeffrey Ding, Oliver Guest, Kevin Wei.

References

Abiri, G., & Huang, Y. (2023). A red flag? China's generative AI dilemma. *Harvard journal of law & technology*, *37*, 1-20.

Achiam, J., Adler, S., Agarwal, S., Ahmad, L., Akkaya, I., Aleman, F. L., ... & McGrew, B. (2023). Gpt-4 technical report. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2303.08774*.

Arcas, B. A. y, & Norvig, P. (2023, October 10). Artificial general intelligence is already here. *NOEMA*. https://www.noemamag.com/artificial-general-intelligence-is-already-here/

Allen, G. (2023). China's pursuit of defense technologies: Implications for U.S. and multilateral export control and investment screening regimes. Center for Strategic and International Studies. https://www.csis.org/analysis/chinas-pursuit-defense-technologies-implications-us-and-multilateral-export-control-and

Altman, S.; Brockman, G., Sutskever, I. (2023, May 22). *Governance of superintelligence*. https://openai.com/index/governance-of-superintelligence/

Altman, S. (2015, February 25). Machine intelligence, part 1. *Blog.SamAltman*. https://blog.samaltman.com/machine-intelligence-part-1

Altman, S. (2025, January 5). Reflections. *Blog.SamAltman*. https://blog.samaltman.com/reflections

Amodei, D. (2023, November 1). *Dario Amodei's prepared remarks from the AI Safety Summit on Anthropic's Responsible Scaling Policy*. Anthropic. https://www.anthropic.com/news/uk-ai-safety-summit

Amodei, D. (2024, October). *Machines of loving grace: How AI could transform the world for the better*. https://www.darioamodei.com/essay/machines-of-loving-grace

Amodei, D. (2025, January). *On DeepSeek and export controls*. Retrieved from https://www.darioamodei.com/post/on-deepseek-and-export-controls

Andreessen, M. (2023, June 6). Why AI will save the world. *Andreessen Horowitz*. https://a16z.com/ai-will-save-the-world/

Anduril Industries. (2024, December 4). Anduril partners with OpenAI to advance U.S. artificial intelligence leadership and protect U.S. and allied forces. Anduril. https://www.anduril.com/article/anduril-partners-with-openai-to-advance-u-s-artificial-intelligence-leadership-and-protect-u-s/

Anthropic. (2025a, March 6). Response to OSTP RFI on the development of an artificial intelligence (AI) action plan. https://assets.anthropic.com/m/4e20a4ab6512e217/original/Anthropic-Response-to-OSTP-RFI-March-2025-Final-Submission-v3.pdf

Anthropic. (2025b, May 14). *Responsible Scaling Policy (Version 2.2)*. https://www-cdn.anthropic.com/872c653b2d0501d6ab44cf87f43e1dc4853e4d37.pdf

Anthropic (2025c, February 11). Statement from Dario Amodei on the Paris AI Action Summit. Anthropic. https://www.anthropic.com/news/paris-ai-summit

Armstrong, S., Bostrom, N., & Shulman, C. (2016). Racing to the precipice: a model of artificial intelligence development. *AI & Society*, *31*, 201-206.

Aschenbrenner, L. (2024). Situational awareness. *The decade ahead. situational-awareness. ai*.

Bank of China. (2025, January 23). *1万亿元！提供专项综合金融支持 助力人工智能产业链发展* [1 trillion yuan! Providing special comprehensive financial support to promote the development of the artificial intelligence industry chain]. https://www.bankofchina.com/aboutboc/bi1/202501/t20250123_25254674.html

Belfield, H., & Ruhl, C. (2022, July 14). *Why policy makers should beware claims of new 'arms races'*. Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists. https://thebulletin.org/2022/07/why-policy-makers-should-beware-claims-of-new-arms-races/

Biddle, S. (2024, January 12). OpenAI quietly deletes ban on using ChatGPT for "military and warfare". The Intercept. https://theintercept.com/2024/01/12/open-ai-military-ban-chatgpt/

Bostrom, N. (2014). Superintelligence: Paths, dangers, strategies. Oxford University Press.

Bradsher, K. (2024). China Tightens Its Hold on Minerals Needed to Make Computer Chips. *New York Times, October*, *26*. https://www.nytimes.com/2024/10/26/business/china-critical-minerals-semiconductors.html

Bresnick, S. (2024). China's Military AI Roadblocks. *Center for Security and Emerging Technology, Georgetown University, Washington, DC*.

Brundage, M., & Werner, G. (2025, April 23). *America First meets Safety First*. AI Frontiers. https://www.ai-frontiers.org/articles/america-first-meets-safety

Bucknall, B., Siddiqui, S., Thurnherr, L., McGurk, C., Harack, B., Reuel, A., Paskov, P., Mahoney, C., Mindermann, S., Singer, S., Hiremath, V., Segerie, C.-R., Delaney, O., Abate, A., Barez, F., Cohen, M. K., Torr, P., Huszár, F., Calinescu, A., Davis Jones, G., Bengio, Y., & Trager, R. (2025). *In which areas of technical AI safety could geopolitical rivals cooperate?* arXiv. https://arxiv.org/abs/2504.12914

Buzan, Barry, Ole Wæver, and Jaap De Wilde. *Security: A new framework for analysis*. Lynne Rienner Publishers, 1998.

Jin, C. (2019). *The Fourth Industrial Revolution Is Mainly a Competition between China and the United States, and China has a Greater Chance of Winning*. Translated by Jeffrey Ding, George Washington University. https://docs.google.com/document/d/1_sNUwHBqU0o8N6PWVQpMBHrs0UshuNXUCJhw5G4qctU

Cave, S., & ÓhÉigeartaigh, S. S. (2018, December). An AI race for strategic advantage: rhetoric and risks. In *Proceedings of the 2018 AAAI/ACM Conference on AI, Ethics, and Society* (pp. 36-40).

Center for AI Safety. (2023, May 30). *Statement on AI risk*. https://safe.ai/work/statement-on-ai-risk

Center for Security and Emerging Technology. (2025, April 28). *At the 20th collective study session of the CCP central committee politburo, Xi Jinping stresses: Persist in being self-reliant, be strongly oriented toward applications, and push the orderly development of artificial intelligence*. Translated by Ben Murphy. Georgetown University. https://cset.georgetown.edu/publication/xi-politburo-collective-study-ai-2025/

Chapman, L., & Ludlow, E. (2025, February). Anduril's Luckey cites China risk in drone output race. *MSN*. https://www.msn.com/en-us/money/companies/anduril-s-luckey-cites-china-risk-in-drone-output-race/ar-AA1xj1nj

ChinaTalk. (2025, April 02). *Is China racing to AGI?* ChinaTalk. https://www.chinatalk.media/p/is-china-agi-pilled

Creemers, R., & Kania, E. (Trans.). (2022, April 22). Translation: Xi Jinping calls for 'healthy development' of AI. *DigiChina*. https://digichina.stanford.edu/work/xi-jinping-calls-for-healthy-development-of-ai-translation/

Clegg, N. (2024, November). Open source AI can help America lead in AI and strengthen global security. Meta. https://about.fb.com/news/2024/11/open-source-ai-america-global-security/

Colson, D. (2024, October 18). Silicon Valley takes artificial general intelligence seriously—Washington must too. *Time*. https://time.com/7093792/ai-artificial-general-intelligence-risks/
Cottier, B., Rahman, R., Fattorini, L., Maslej, N., & Owen, D. (2024). The rising costs of training frontier AI models. arXiv. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2405.21015
FireEye. (2019). *APT41: A dual espionage and cyber crime operation*. https://www.fireeye.com/current-threats/apt-groups.html
Demchak, C. C. (2019). China: determined to dominate cyberspace and AI. *Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists, 75*(3), 99–104.
Ding, Jeffrey, and Allan Dafoe. "Engines of power: Electricity, AI, and general-purpose, military transformations." *European Journal of International Security* 8.3 (2023): 377-394.
Ding, J. (2024). Technology and the rise of great powers: how diffusion shapes economic competition. Princeton University Press.
Douthat, R. (2025, May 21). *J.D. Vance's theological border wall*. The New York Times. https://www.nytimes.com/2025/05/21/opinion/jd-vance-pope-trump-immigration.html
Esper, M. T. (2019, November 5). Remarks at National Security Commission on Artificial Intelligence Public Conference [Speech transcript]. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Defense. Retrieved from https://www.defense.gov/News/Transcripts/Transcript/Article/2011960/remarks-by-secretary-esper-at-national-security-commission-on-artificial-intell/
Executive Office of the President. (2023, November 1). Safe, secure, and trustworthy development and use of artificial intelligence. Federal Register, 88(210), 75358-75377. https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2023/11/01/2023-24283/safe-secure-and-trustworthy-development-and-use-of-artificial-intelligence
Fedasiuk, R., Melot, J., & Murphy, B. (2021). Harnessed lightning: How the Chinese military is adopting artificial intelligence. Center for Security and Emerging Technology. https://cset.georgetown.edu/publication/harnessed-lightning/
FireEye. (2013). *APT1: Exposing One of China's Cyber Espionage Units*. Retrieved from https://www.fireeye.com/content/dam/fireeye-www/services/pdfs/mandiant-apt1-report.pdf
Gadzala Tirziu, A. (2024, December). China's military expansion: A global power shift in the making. GIS Reports. https://www.gisreportsonline.com/r/china-military-expansion/
Gao, W. (2025) *Seizing the Historic Opportunity for the Development of Artificial Intelligence*. Translated by Bill Bishop. Sinocism. https://abalone-taleggio-85c.notion.site/Seizing-the-Historic-Opportunity-for-the-Development-of-Artificial-Intelligence-1a41b804835280a78b44d17e0ef92a04
General Office of the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology. (2023, September 15). 国务院办公厅关于进一步优化营商环境降低市场主体制度性交易成本的意见. The Central People's Government of the People's Republic of China. https://web.archive.org/web/20230916063228/https://www.gov.cn/zhengce/zhengceku/202309/content_6903897.htm
Gigova, R. (2017, September 4). Putin: Whoever leads in AI will rule the world. CNN. https://edition.cnn.com/2017/09/01/world/putin-artificial-intelligence-will-rule-world/index.html Retrieved 4 April 2025
Geopolitechs. (2025, January 21). Translation: China's Vice Premier Ding Xuexiang on AI competition and AI governance at Davos. *Geopolitechs*. https://www.geopolitechs.org/p/chinas-vice-premier-ding-xuexiang
Griffin, J. (2024, May 16). Modern warfare being reshaped by AI [Video]. Fox News. https://www.foxnews.com/video/6352982729112

Hart, J. (2025, May 22). *Google cofounder Sergey Brin says it's time for retired computer scientists to get back to work*. Business Insider. https://www.businessinsider.com/google-sergey-brin-computer-scientists-should-not-be-retired-2025-5
Hendrycks, D., Mazeika, M., & Woodside, T. (2023). An overview of catastrophic AI risks. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2306.12001*.
Hendrycks, D., Schmidt, E., & Wang, A. (2025). *Superintelligence strategy: Expert version*. arXiv. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2503.05628
Hooker, L., & Vallance, C. (2025, February 5). Google ending AI arms ban incredibly concerning, campaigners say. BBC News. https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/cy081nqx2zjo
IDAIS-Beijing. (2024, March). Consensus Statement on Red Lines in Artificial Intelligence. https://idais.ai/
Jones, N. (2025) How AI can achieve human-level intelligence: researchers call for change in tack. *Nature*. https://doi.org/10.1038/d41586-025-00649-4
Joshi, S. (2025). A Comprehensive Review of DeepSeek: Performance, Architecture and Capabilities. Preprints. https://doi.org/10.20944/preprints202503.1887.v1
Karp, Alexander C. (2023): "Our Oppenheimer Moment: The Creation of AI Weapons." *International New York Times*. https://www.nytimes.com/2023/07/25/opinion/karp-palantir-artificial-intelligence.html
Katzke, C., & Futerman, G. (2024). *The Manhattan Trap: Why a Race to Artificial Superintelligence is Self-Defeating*. SSRN. https://ssrn.com/abstract=5067833
Kerner, S. (2023, July). Elon Musk reveals xAI efforts, predicts full AGI by 2029. VentureBeat. https://venturebeat.com/ai/elon-musk-reveals-xai-efforts-predicts-full-agi-by-2029
Klein, E. (2025, March 4). The government knows A.G.I. is coming. *The New York Times*. https://www.nytimes.com/2025/03/04/opinion/ezra-klein-podcast-ben-buchanan.html
Kraft, A. (2024). Pugwash in the 1960s Cold War: Challenges and Limits of Operating in the Diplomatic Realm. In *The Palgrave Handbook of Non-State Actors in East-West Relations* (pp. 1-21). Cham: Springer International Publishing.
Kumar, I., & Manning, S. (2025). Trends in Frontier AI Model Count: A Forecast to 2028. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2504.16138*.
Lee, K. F. (2018). *AI superpowers: China, Silicon Valley, and the new world order*. Harper Business.
Lehane, C. (2025, March 13). OpenAI response: OSTP/NSF RFI. *OpenAI*. https://cdn.openai.com/global-affairs/ostp-rfi/ec680b75-d539-4653-b297-8bcf6e5f7686/openai-response-ostp-nsf-rfi-notice-request-for-information-on-the-development-of-an-artificial-intelligence-ai-action-plan.pdf
Levine, J. & Hwang, T. (2025). Copyright, Power and Great Power Competition. *Foundation for American Innovation*. Research Papers. https://cdn.sanity.io/files/d8lrla4f/staging/1e8b069431e03d9e8b23f03dede131ef5fdb16a9.pdf
Liu, A., Feng, B., Xue, B., Wang, B., Wu, B., Lu, C., ... & Piao, Y. (2024). Deepseek-v3 technical report. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2412.19437*.
Liu, Y., Zhang, Y., Duan, P., Shi, B., Yu, Z., Huang, T., & Gao, W. (2021). Technical countermeasures for security risks of artificial general intelligence. *Strategic Study of CAE*, *23*(3), 75–81. https://doi.org/10.15302/J-SSCAE-2021.03.005
Loke, K., Triolo, P., Toner, H., Costigan, J., Singer, S., Wagner, G., Zhou, J., & Neville, K. (2025, April 30). *Forum: Xi's message to the Politburo on AI*. DigiChina. https://digichina.stanford.edu/work/forum-xis-message-to-the-politburo-on-ai/
Lovely, G. (2024, November 19). *China Hawks are manufacturing an AI arms race (Now with a reply from Gwern)*. Obsolete. https://www.obsolete.pub/p/china-hawks-are-manufacturing-an

Mayer Brown. (2024, September 9). US Department of Commerce issues proposal to require reporting development of advanced AI models and computer clusters. https://www.mayerbrown.com/en/insights/publications/2024/09/us-department-of-commerce-issues-proposal-to-require-reporting-development-of-advanced-ai-models-and-computer-clusters

Maslej, N., Fattorini, L., Perrault, R., Gil, Y., Parli, V., Kariuki, N., Capstick, E., Reuel, A., Brynjolfsson, E., Etchemendy, J., Ligett, K., Lyons, T., Manyika, J., Niebles, J. C., Shoham, Y., Wald, R., Walsh, T., Hamrah, A., Santarlasci, L., Betts Lotufo, J., Rome, A., Shi, A., & Oak, S. (2025, April). The AI Index 2025 Annual Report. AI Index Steering Committee, Institute for Human-Centered AI, Stanford University. https://hai-production.s3.amazonaws.com/files/hai_ai_index_report_2025.pdf

Milmo, D. (2023, October 24). *AI risk must be treated as seriously as climate crisis, says Google DeepMind chief*. The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2023/oct/24/ai-risk-climate-crisis-google-deepmind-chief-demis-hassabis-regulation

Miller, S. E. (2021). Nuclear hotlines: Origins, evolution, applications. Journal for Peace and Nuclear Disarmament, 4(sup1), 176-191.

Mitchell, M. (2024). Debates on the nature of artificial general intelligence. *Science*, *383*(6689), eado7069.

Mozur, P., Liu, J., & Metz, C. (2024). China's Rush to Dominate AI Comes With a Twist: It Depends Upon US Technology. *The New York Times. ISSN*, 0362-4331.

Murgia, M. (2024, December 5). Anthropic's Dario Amodei: Democracies must maintain the lead in AI. Financial Times. https://www.ft.com/content/e75e3388-4700-413d-ab67-778410c2d977

Musk, E. [@elonmusk]. (2017, September 4). [Tweet]. Twitter. https://x.com/elonmusk/status/904638455761612800

Narayanan, A., & Kapoor, S. (2025, April 15). *AI as normal technology: An alternative to the vision of AI as a potential superintelligence*. Knight First Amendment Institute. https://kfai-documents.s3.amazonaws.com/documents/0ee1da899a/AI-as-Normal-Technology---Narayanan---Kapoor-Final.pdf

O'Gara, A., Kulp, G., Hodgkins, W., Petrie, J., Immler, V., Aysu, A., ... & Srivastava, A. (2025). Hardware-Enabled Mechanisms for Verifying Responsible AI Development. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2505.03742*.

ÓhÉigeartaigh, S. S., Whittlestone, J., Liu, Y., Zeng, Y., & Liu, Z. (2020). Overcoming barriers to cross-cultural cooperation in AI ethics and governance. *Philosophy & technology*, *33*, 571-593.

O'Meara, S. (2019). China's ambitious quest to lead the world in AI by 2030. *Nature*, *572*(7770), 427-428.

Ó hÉigeartaigh, S. (2025). What comes after the Paris AI Summit? *Royal United Services Institute*. https://www.rusi.org/explore-our-research/publications/commentary/what-comes-after-paris-ai-summit

OpenAI. (2025a, April 15). *Preparedness Framework (Version 2)*. https://cdn.openai.com/pdf/18a02b5d-6b67-4cec-ab64-68cdfbddebcd/preparedness-framework-v2.pdf

OpenAI (2025b, March 31). *New funding to build towards AGI* https://openai.com/index/march-funding-updates/

Palantir Investor Relations. (2024, November 7). Anthropic and Palantir partner to bring Claude AI models to AWS for U.S. government intelligence and defense operations. Palantir Investor Relations. https://investors.palantir.com/news-details/2024/Anthropic-and-Palantir-Partner-to-Bring-Claude-AI-Models-to-AWS-for-U.S.-Government-Intelligence-and-Defense-Operations/

Petrie, J., Aarne, O., Ammann, N., & Dalrymple, D. D. (2025, April). *Flexible Hardware-Enabled Guarantees: Part I – Overview*. Advanced Research and Invention Agency. https://flexheg.com/report-1.pdf

People's Republic of China. (2021, December). *China's positions on international rules-making in cyberspace*. United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs. https://documents.unoda.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/12/Chinese-Position-Paper-on-International-Rules-making-in-Cyberspace-ENG.pdf
People's Republic of China (2021). Position Paper of the People's Republic of China on Regulating Military Applications of Artificial Intelligence (AI). Sixth Review Conference of the High Contracting Parties to the Convention on Prohibitions or Restrictions on the Use of Certain Conventional Weapons Which May Be Deemed to Be Excessively Injurious or to Have Indiscriminate Effects. https://docs-library.unoda.org/Convention_on_Certain_Conventional_Weapons_-SixthReview_Conference_(2021)/CCW-CONF.VI-WP.2.pdf
Pichai, S. (2023, April 20). Google DeepMind: Bringing together two world-class AI teams. Google. https://blog.google/technology/ai/april-ai-update/
Pillay, T. (2025, March 13). How Musk, Altman, AI leaders face the 'Oppenheimer moment.' *Time*. https://time.com/7267797/ai-leaders-oppenheimer-moment-musk-altman/
Pilz, K. F., Heim, L., & Brown, N. (2025a). Increased compute efficiency and the diffusion of AI capabilities. In *Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence* (Vol. 39, No. 26, pp. 27582-27590).
Pilz, K. F., Sanders, J., Rahman, R., & Heim, L. (2025b). Trends in AI supercomputers. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2504.16026*.
PYMNTS. (2025, February 20). *Alibaba ramps up AI spending in pursuit of AGI*. PYMNTS.com. https://www.pymnts.com/earnings/2025/alibaba-ramps-up-ai-spending-in-pursuit-of-agi/
Rehman, I. (2025, January 13). *The battle for brilliant minds: From the nuclear age to AI*. War on the Rocks. https://warontherocks.com/2025/01/the-battle-for-brilliant-minds-from-the-nuclear-age-to-ai
Roose, K. (2023, December 6). Silicon Valley confronts a grim new A.I. metric. *The New York Times*. https://www.nytimes.com/2023/12/06/business/dealbook/silicon-valley-artificial-intelligence.html
Sacks, D. [@DavidSacks]. (2025, January 27). [Tweet]. X. https://x.com/DavidSacks/status/1883935713877782884
Schmidt, E., & Work, R. O. (2021). Chair and vice chair letter - NSCAI final report. *National Security Commission on Artificial Intelligence*. https://reports.nscai.gov/final-report/chair-and-vice-chair-letter
Schneider, J., Shen, A., Zhang, I., et al. (2024, November 27). DeepSeek: The quiet giant leading China's AI race. *ChinaTalk*. https://www.chinatalk.media/p/deepseek-ceo-interview-with-chinas
Scott, L. (2013). Intelligence and the risk of nuclear war: Able Archer-83 revisited. In *Intelligence in the Cold War: What Difference did it Make?* (pp. 5-23). Routledge.
Sevilla, J., & Roldan, E. (2024). Training compute of frontier AI models grows by 4-5x per year. *Epoch AI*. Retrieved May 10, 2025, from https://epoch.ai/blog/training-compute-of-frontier-ai-models-grows-by-4-5x-per-year
Shah, R., Irpan, A., Turner, A. M., Wang, A., Conmy, A., Lindner, D., ... & Dragan, A. (2025). An approach to technical agi safety and security. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2504.01849*.
Shanahan, M. (2015). *The technological singularity*. MIT press.
Shead, S. (2017). Eric Schmidt on AI: 'Trust me, these Chinese people are good'. *Business Insider*. Available at: https://www.businessinsider.com/eric-schmidt-on-artificial-intelligence-china-2017-11/. Accessed 30 Dec 2017.
Sheehan, M. (2023). China's AI regulations and how they get made. *Horizons: Journal of International Relations and Sustainable Development*, (24), 108-125.
Shipley, T. (2024, October 28). China will continue to advance its military AI. https://www.oxan.com/insights/china-will-continue-to-advance-its-military-ai/

Shoker, S., Reddie, A., Barrington, S., Booth, R., Brundage, M., Chahal, H., ... & Young, J. (2023). Confidence-building measures for artificial intelligence: Workshop proceedings. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2308.00862*.
Solomon, J. (2023, July 28). Ex-Pentagon chief: US, China locked in existential struggle for AI dominance. *Semafor*. https://www.semafor.com/article/07/27/2023/us-china-existential-struggle-ai-dominance
South China Morning Post. (2023, August 23). China's 'pro-innovation' AI regulations augur well for eventual public release of Ernie Bot and other local ChatGPT alternatives, Baidu CEO says. https://www.scmp.com/tech/big-tech/article/3232071/chinas-pro-innovation-ai-regulations-augur-well-eventual-public-release-ernie-bot-and-other-local
Stacey, K. & Gilbert, C. (2022) Big Tech increases funding to US foreign policy think-tanks. *Financial Times*. Retrieved May 13, 2025 from. https://www.ft.com/content/4e4ca1d2-2d80-4662-86d0-067a10aad50b
Stokes, J. (2024, February 1). Military artificial intelligence, the People's Liberation Army, and U.S.-China strategic competition. Center for a New American Security. https://www.cnas.org/publications/congressional-testimony/military-artificial-intelligence-the-peoples-liberation-army-and-u-s-china-strategic-competition
Su, J., Deng, Y., & Shang, E. (2023, August 31). Baidu's Ernie Bot among eight Chinese LLM products approved for public launch. KrASIA. https://kr-asia.com/baidus-ernie-bot-among-eight-chinese-llm-products-approved-for-public-launch
Sutskever, I., Gross, D., & Levy, D. (2024, June 19). *Safe Superintelligence Inc.* Safe Superintelligence Inc. https://ssi.inc/
Tech Transparency Project. (2024). Eric Schmidt cozies up to China's AI industry while warning U.S. of its dangers. Retrieved May 19, 2025, from https://www.techtransparencyproject.org/articles/eric-schmidt-cozies-up-to-chinas-ai-industry-while
The Economist. (2025, February 22). *AI bosses on what keeps them up at night* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4poqjZlM8Lo
The State Council of the People's Republic of China. (2024, July 21). Full text: Resolution of CPC Central Committee on further deepening reform comprehensively to advance Chinese modernization. https://english.www.gov.cn/policies/latestreleases/202407/21/content_WS669d0255c6d0868f4e8e94f8.html
Tobin, M. (2023, July 3). Will China overtake the U.S. on AI? Probably not. Here's why. The Washington Post. https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/2023/07/03/china-us-ai-technology-chatgpt/
Tognini, G., & Liu, P. (2025, January 30). Here's how much AI firm DeepSeek and its founder are worth. Forbes. https://www.forbes.com/sites/giacomotognini/2025/01/30/how-much-ai-firm-deepseek-and-its-billionaire-founder-liang-wenfeng-are-net-worth/
Toner, H., Xiao, J., & Ding, J. (2023). The illusion of China's AI prowess. *Foreign Affairs*, *2*.
Tong, A., & Martina, M. (2024, November 19). *US government commission pushes Manhattan Project-style AI initiative*. Reuters. https://www.reuters.com/technology/artificial-intelligence/us-government-commission-pushes-manhattan-project-style-ai-initiative-2024-11-19
Trager, R., Harack, B., Reuel, A., Carnegie, A., Heim, L., Ho, L., ... & Villalobos, J. J. (2023). International governance of civilian AI: A jurisdictional certification approach. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2308.15514*.
Tyrangiel, J. (2025, February 1). Sam Altman on ChatGPT's first two years, Elon Musk and AI under Trump. *Bloomberg Businessweek*. https://www.bloomberg.com/features/2025-sam-altman-interview/

U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission. (2024). *2024 Annual report to Congress*. U.S. Government Publishing Office. https://www.uscc.gov/sites/default/files/2024-11/2024_Annual_Report_to_Congress.pdf
U.S. Department of Commerce. (2022, October 7). Commerce implements new export controls on advanced computing and semiconductor manufacturing items to the People's Republic of China (PRC) [Press release]. Retrieved from https://www.bis.doc.gov/index.php/documents/about-bis/newsroom/press-releases/3158-2022-10-07-bis-press-release-advanced-computing-and-semiconductor-manufacturing-controls-final/file
U.S. Department of Justice. (2025, March 5). *Justice Department charges 12 Chinese contract hackers and law enforcement officers in global computer intrusion campaigns*. https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/justice-department-charges-12-chinese-contract-hackers-and-law-enforcement-officers-global
U.S. Department of Justice. (2014, May 19). *U.S. charges five Chinese military hackers for cyber espionage against U.S. corporations* [Press release]. https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/us-charges-five-chinese-military-hackers-cyber-espionage-against-us-corporations-and
VandeHei, J., & Allen, M. (2025, January 18). *Behind the Curtain: A chilling, "catastrophic" warning*. Axios. https://www.axios.com/2025/01/18/biden-sullivan-ai-race-trump-china
Villalobos, P., Ho, A., Sevilla, J., Besiroglu, T., Heim, L., & Hobbhahn, M. (2024). Will we run out of data? Limits of LLM scaling based on human-generated data. arXiv. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2211.04325
Wang, A. (2022, November 27). The AI war and how to win it. *Rational in the Fullness of Time*. https://alexw.substack.com/p/war
Werner, G. (2024, August 23). *The AI arms race isn't inevitable*. Palladium Magazine. https://www.palladiummag.com/2024/08/23/the-ai-arms-race-isnt-inevitable/
Xi, J. (2018, July 26). *Turn our vision into a reality* [Speech transcript]. Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China. https://www.mfa.gov.cn/eng/zy/jj/2018zt/xgswfcxjxgjmlqs/202406/t20240606_11380535.html
Xinhua News Agency. (2023, April 28). 中共中央政治局召开会议 分析研究当前经济形势和经济工作 中共中央总书记习近平主持会议. 中国政府网. https://www.gov.cn/yaowen/2023-04/28/content_5753652.htm
Yahoo Finance. (2025, February 24). *Alibaba to spend $53 billion on AI infrastructure in big pivot*. https://finance.yahoo.com/news/alibaba-spend-53-billion-ai-022846544.html
Fu, Y. (2025, February 17). Fu Ying: As long as U.S. and China can cooperate and work together, we'll find a way to keep AI under control. *China US Focus*. https://www.chinausfocus.com/peace-security/fu-ying-as-long-as-the-us-and-china-can-cooperate-and-work-together-with-the-rest-of-humanity-well-find-a-way-to-keep-ai-under-control
Yousif, N., & Tidy, J. (2024, December 30). *US Treasury says it was hacked by China in 'major incident'*. BBC News. https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c3weye2j0e7o
Zhao, G. (2023, March 5). Zhu Songchun: Develop general artificial intelligence like the "Two Bombs, One Satellite" project. China Science Daily. https://news.sciencenet.cn/htmlnews/2023/3/495294.shtm